had them torn to the proper length. If, while walking through the streets, he heard the noise of any singing he would start violently.'

At this stage, though Badauni received an orthodox religious education, he was also intensely interested in intellectual discourse and mysticism as well as history, Persian, Hindustani music, astronomy, and the law. At Shaikh Mubarak's madrasa, Badauni met Abu'l Fazl and Faizi, beginning a forty-year-long association that would bring him only bitterness and disappointment.

While Shaikh Mubarak's madrasa was fizzing with enquiry and arguments, and the Padshah was occupied with a more visceral experience of his kingdom, the management of state was largely carried out by Munim Khan and Maham Anaga. At the very start of the new dispensation, after the fall of Bairam Khan, it was Shahabuddin Ahmad Khan who consulted with his mother-in-law, Maham Anaga, and 'gave everyone who came to the threshold…hopes of rank and jagir…' All Maham Anaga's supporters were generously rewarded and, when Munim Khan became wakil, Maham Anaga was prompt in showing him allegiance. Abu'l Fazl wrote later that no matter who held the title of wakil, the real business was transacted by Maham Anaga 'for this noble work, wisdom and courage was necessary, and in truth, Maham Anaga possessed these two qualities in perfection'.

There were other commentators who would not be so accepting of the visible role of a powerful woman. Writing about this episode in Akbar's reign, Badauni would gloomily quote from the *Nahj-ul Balaghat* to describe this new order of affairs, a veritable end-of-world scenario:

> A time will come on men, when none will become favourites but profligates, and none be thought witty but the obscene, and none thought weak but the just; when they shall account the alms a heavy imposition and the bond of relationship a reproach, and the service of God shall be a weariness unto them, and then the government shall be by the counsel of women, and the rule of boys, and the management of eunuchs.

Working alongside Maham Anaga was Munim Khan, and while Maham Anaga was considered a capable woman, Munim Khan was shackled by an overly conciliatory attitude, wishing to remain friendly with all the different clans that made up the nobility. He failed to take any measures to keep the privileges and independence of the nobility checked. On the contrary, it was